Leftovers of this big warming soup from Tuscany are never thrown away, but used to make the sturdy Ribollita (see right). Both are frugally filling and very good.

zuppa di verdure

SERVES 6 **PREP** 25 MINS, PLUS OVERNIGHT SOAKING **COOK** 2–3 HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS BEFORE CAVOLO NERO IS ADDED

7oz (200g) dried cannellini beans, soaked overnight in water, or 1 x 14oz (400g) can cannellini beans, drained and rinsed
bouquet garni made from a sprig of rosemary, a sprig of thyme, and 2 bay leaves (see p24)
4 tbsp extra virgin olive oil, plus extra to serve
1 onion, chopped
3 carrots, diced
2 celery ribs, diced
2 leeks, very thinly sliced
3 garlic cloves, chopped
1 dried red chile pepper, finely chopped
3 tomatoes, peeled, seeded, and chopped
2 tbsp tomato purée
salt and freshly ground black pepper
4 cavolo nero or curly kale leaves, or the outer leaves of a Savoy cabbage, tough stalks removed and the leaves coarsely chopped
6 slices stale bread
1 garlic clove, cut in half

1 Drain the beans and place them in a large pan with the bouquet garni and twice their volume of cold water. Bring to a boil, then boil hard for 10 minutes. Lower the heat, and simmer gently for 1–2 hours or until tender, adding more water if needed. Remove the pan from the heat, discard the bouquet garni, and leave the beans to cool in their cooking water.

2 Heat the oil in a large heavy pot, then add the onion, carrots, celery, leeks, garlic, and chile. Cover with a lid and sweat over low heat for 10 minutes, stirring once or twice. Add the tomatoes and tomato purée and cook over a moderate heat for 3–4 minutes. Add the beans, their cooking water, and enough water to cover the vegetables generously. Season well with salt and pepper. Bring to a boil and simmer gently for 20 minutes or until the vegetables are tender. Purée half the soup in a blender, then return to the pan. Add the cavolo nero and simmer for 10 minutes or until tender. Adjust the seasonings.

3 Rub the bread with the garlic and arrange in a warm shallow casserole dish. Spoon in the soup and serve with a bottle of high-quality olive oil out on the table for people to help themselves.